

The lead female character of *Silappathikaram* is Kannagi. Her father is Maanaigan. Sea traders are known by the name Maanaigan. The male character Kovalan's father is Maasathuvan. Massathuvan means a big trader. It is clear from the text that Poompuhar was a place where big traders and sea traders had settled down.

Numerous merchants from foreign countries such as Greece and Rome landed at Poompuhar. Due to busy and continuous trade, many of them stayed on indefinitely in Poompuhar. There are evidences of foreigner's settlements in the town. People speaking many languages inhabited Poompuhar in its glorious days. As loading and unloading of ships took some months, the foreign traders began to interact with the local people during that period. This enabled the natives to learn foreign languages for communication. Similarly, the foreigners also learnt Tamil to communicate with the natives. This contact facilitated not only exchange of goods but also languages and ideas resulting in cultural blending.

The traders of Poompuhar were known for their honesty and integrity. They sold goods at legitimate prices. *Pattinappaalai* states that "selling any commodity at a higher price was considered bad".

The author of *Pattinappaalai*, Kadiyalur Uruttirangannanar, belonged to 2nd century BC(BCE). This is indicative of Puhar's antiquity. Horses were imported by sea. Pepper was procured through the land route. Gold that came from Vadamalai was polished and exported to the overseas countries. Sandal from Western Ghats, pearls from southern sea, corals from eastern sea and food items from Eelam were imported.

Poompuhar had been built differently from other towns. Each social group had a separate settlement. Streets were broad and straight, dotted with well-designed houses. There was also a dockyard.

We can learn about the life of the people of Puhar by reading Pattinappaalai and "Puhar Kandam" of *Silappathikaram.*

Puhar was a busy port upto 200 AD(CE). It might have been either washed away by sea or destroyed by big shore waves. The remains of that destruction can still be seen in the present Poompuhar town.

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